

Ashwini Vaishnaw flags off 20-coach Vande Bharat linking Jammu and Srinagar

IITM Bureau

Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Thursday (April 30, 2026) flagged off the extended Vande Bharat Express service connecting Jammu Tawi with Srinagar via Kathra, marking a major step in enhancing rail connectivity across Jammu and Kashmir. Addressing the occasion, Vaishnaw said that strengthening maintenance practices remains central to ensuring safety and security, while the next priority is to increase capacity on the Jammu-Srinagar rail corridor through track doubling. He highlighted that the Qazigund-Arinagar section is being taken up for doubling,

Reform-Linked MoUs under JJM 2.0 Signed with Uttarakhand, Karnataka and Tripura

IITM Bureau

Reform-linked Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 were signed on April 29, 2026, with the states of Uttarakhand, Karnataka, and Tripura, following the approval of the Union Cabinet in March this year. The signing ceremony was presided over by Union Jal Shakti Minister C. R. Patil, while the Chief Ministers of the participating states joined the meeting virtually. According to the Ministry of Jal Shakti, the reform-linked MoUs emphasize a Gram Panchayat-led, service-based, and community-centred approach to rural wa-

Veteran Photographer Raghu Rai Dies at 83 After Battle with Cancer; PM expresses grief

IITM Bureau

Veteran Indian photographer Raghu Rai passed away on April 26, 2026, after a prolonged two-year battle with cancer. He was 83. Widely regarded as one of the most influential visual storytellers of modern India, Rai leaves behind an extraordinary legacy that shaped the course of documentary photography in the country and beyond.

Born on December 18, 1942, in Jhang (now in Pakistan), Raghu Rai rose to international prominence through his compelling and deeply humanistic

which will enable more trains to operate on the route. The Minister noted that the Vande Bharat service on the Jammu-Katra-Srinagar route has witnessed overwhelming demand, operating at full capacity with over 5.5 lakh passengers travelling so far. He added that the train is equipped with advanced technology to function in extreme weather conditions, including temperatures as low as minus 10 degrees Celsius, with specialised systems to prevent freezing. Highlighting its economic impact, Vaishnav said the rail link has supported cargo movement from the Valley, with nearly 2 crore kilograms of



apples transported to Delhi and dedicated bookings made for cherry consignments. Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said the enhanced service will significantly benefit both passengers and trade. He noted that the increase from 8 to 20 coaches has raised the train's capacity to around 1,400 passengers, while also improving freight

movement, including transport of construction material, vehicles and horticulture produce. Union Minister Jitendra Singh credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Railway Ministry for completing the long-pending rail link to the Kashmir Valley, calling it a major milestone in regional connectivity. The train, which earlier operated between Srinagar

and Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra, will now run up to Jammu Tawi, integrating the Valley more directly with the national rail network. The service will commence regular operations from May 2, 2026, with two pairs of trains running six days a week, offering both morning and afternoon options from Jammu and Srinagar. The project is part of the broader Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL), one of India's most ambitious railway infrastructure initiatives. Key engineering landmarks along the route include the Chenab Rail Bridge, the world's highest railway arch bridge.

West Bengal records highest-ever voter turnout since Independence; Phase 2 election sees 91.66% polling

IITM Bureau

West Bengal has recorded its highest-ever voter turnout since Independence, with an impressive 91.66% polling in Phase two of the Assembly elections on April 29, said the Election Commission of India (ECI). Polling for Phase-II began at 7:00 AM and continued till evening, with voter participation reaching 91.66% by 7:45 PM. Combined with Phase-I turnout of 93.19%, the overall polling percentage across the first two phases stands at a record 92.47%, surpassing the previous high of 84.72% recorded in the 2011 Assembly elections. Gender-wise data for Phase-II indi-

Supreme Court upholds mandatory admission of students under the Right to Education Act

IITM Bureau

The Supreme Court of India on April 28, 2026, delivered a significant judgment reinforcing the spirit and implementation of the Right to Education Act, declaring it a “national mission” aimed at ensuring inclusive and equitable education. The Court held that all neighbourhood schools, including private unaided institutions, are legally obligated to admit students allotted to them by the state government without any delay or resistance. A bench comprising Justices PS Narasimha

The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has issued a comprehensive set of guidelines on April 28, 2026, to safeguard workers and ensure the smooth functioning of National Highway projects amid the ongoing heatwave conditions across the country. Recognizing the serious health risks posed by extreme temperatures, the authority has directed contractors and project agencies to implement immediate measures aimed at protecting labourers engaged in highway construction and maintenance activities. One of the key directives issued by NHAI is the

restriction of outdoor work during peak heat hours, specifically between 12 noon and 4 PM, when temperatures are at their highest. Contractors have been instructed to reschedule labour-intensive tasks such as asphalt laying, road surfacing, and welding to early morning or late evening hours, thereby minimizing workers' exposure to harsh sunlight and heat stress. In addition to rescheduling work hours, NHAH has made it mandatory for all project sites to provide adequate rest and cooling arrangements. Workers must be given regular breaks in shaded areas equipped with proper ventilation. The guidelines also empha-

size the availability of safe drinking water at all times, along with essential health support such as first-aid kits, Oral Rehydration Salts (ORS), and glucose to prevent dehydration and fatigue. Furthermore, NHAH has stressed the importance of awareness and preparedness among workers. Labourers will be trained to recognize early symptoms of heat-related illnesses, including heat exhaustion and heatstroke, enabling timely intervention and medical assistance. Supervisors and site managers are expected to closely monitor workers' health conditions during working hours. To ensure strict adherence to these measures.



ter governance. This model aligns with the broader objectives of Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0, focusing on decentralization and strengthening grassroots participation. The agreements aim to ensure that every rural household receives a regular supply of safe and adequate drinking water, meeting prescribed quality standards. A key feature of these MoUs is the integra-

tion of structural reforms to promote sustainable operation and maintenance of rural water supply systems. By empowering local governance institutions such as Gram Panchayats, the initiative seeks to create a sense of ownership among communities, thereby improving long-term service delivery and accountability. The focus on community participation is

expected to enhance both efficiency and sustainability in water management practices. Speaking on the occasion, C. R. Patil highlighted that the Jal Jeevan Mission has evolved into a people-centric movement, significantly impacting rural India by improving dignity, health, and overall quality of life. He further noted that with the mission's extended deadline until December 2028, the government aims to achieve 100 percent tap water coverage and improved sanitation facilities across the country. The Minister also urged the participating states to continue their efforts and ensure effective implementation of operation.

cates strong participation across all groups, with female voter turnout at 92.28%, higher than male turnout at 91.07%, while third-gender participation stood at 91.28%. Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, along with Election Commissioners S. S. Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, monitored the polling process closely through live webcasting, which was implemented across 100% of polling stations in Phase-II. Election Commission said the high turnout reflects robust voter engagement and confidence in the electoral process. Several voter-friendly initiatives were implemented to enhance participation,



including colour photographs of candidates on EVM ballot papers, mobile deposit facilities, redesigned voter information slips, and a cap of 1,200 electors per polling station to reduce crowding. Special arrangements were also made to assist Persons with Disabilities (PwD), including provision of wheelchairs, volunteers, and transport facilities to polling stations. Across both phases, polling was conducted in 294 As-

sembly constituencies spanning 24 districts, with over 6.81 crore electors and nearly 2,926 candidates in the fray. More than 85,000 polling stations and over 4.26 lakh polling personnel were deployed to ensure smooth conduct of elections. The ECI noted that the turnout figures are provisional and do not yet include service voters and postal ballots. Final figures will be released after complete data compilation.

testimony to the tragedy. Earlier, his work during the Bangladesh Liberation War earned him the prestigious Padma Shri in 1972, making him one of the youngest recipients of the honour at the time. Rai's contributions received widespread international recognition. In 1992, he was named "Photographer of the Year" in the United States, further cementing his global stature.

suffering caused by one of the world's worst industrial disasters. His evocative images not only raised global awareness but also became a lasting

In 2019, he was awarded the Académie des Beaux-Arts Photography Award, one of the highest international honours in the field of photography. The Min-

istry of Information and Broadcasting also honoured him with a Lifetime Achievement Award in 2017, acknowledging his immense contribution to Indian visual culture. Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed deep grief over Rai's demise. In a social media message, he described Raghu Rai as a creative stalwart who captured India's vibrancy through his lens. He noted that Rai's photography was marked by extraordinary sensitivity, depth, and diversity, bringing people closer to the many facets of Indian life.

and Alok Aradhe observed that denial of admission to children belonging to weaker and disadvantaged sections directly violates their fundamental right to education guaranteed under Article 21A of the Constitution. The ruling underscores that access to education is not merely a policy directive but a constitutional mandate that must be strictly enforced. Highlighting the transformative potential of the 25 per cent reservation provision under the RTE Act, the Court noted that such measures can significantly reshape the

social fabric of the country by promoting equality and reducing socio-economic disparities. It stressed that the effective and sincere implementation of this provision is essential to achieve the broader goal of free and compulsory education for all children. The apex court's decision came while dismissing an appeal filed by a Lucknow-based private school that had refused admission to a student despite her selection under the RTE framework. Upholding the earlier decision of the High Court, the bench made it clear that private

institutions cannot question or override the eligibility criteria or selection process conducted by government authorities. The Court further ruled that once the state government forwards the list of selected candidates, schools are duty-bound to comply and grant admission. Any attempt to obstruct or delay this process, the Court warned, would undermine the very objective of the law and render the fundamental right to education ineffective. This judgment sends a strong message to educational institutions across the country.

Two Jewish Men Stabbed In London, Police Treat Attack As Terrorism

IITM Bureau

Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah has been sworn in as Nepal's prime minister after a landslide victory in the country's first election since last year's youth-led protests. The 35-year-old's rise marks an important shift in Nepali politics. His promise of change resonated with an electorate that was angry at corruption, nepotism and elite rule. Before taking office on Friday (March 27 2026), Shah, popularly known as Balen, released a song filled with optimism about Nepal's future. "Undivided Nepali, this time history is being made," he rapped in a track that garnered more than two million views



within hours of its release. The song harks back to his roots in the underground rap scene, where he used music to call out corruption and other social problems in Nepal. After just three years as mayor of the capital Kathmandu, Shah teamed up with the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) Kathmandu, and is as its prime-ministerial candidate, scoring a decisive victory in general elections this

month. His supporters see him as a symbol of change and a break from the failings of Nepal's old guard. But some question whether the four-year-old RSP is capable of making good on its bold pledges. The rebellious rapper Shah was born up with the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) Kathmandu, and is his parents' youngest son. His father is an Ayurvedic practitioner and his mother stayed

at home to bring up the family. Shah is married and lives with his wife and daughter. After leaving school he graduated with engineering degrees in Kathmandu and later in the southern Indian state of Karnataka. In 2013, he shot to fame after winning a popular rap battle in Nepal, with sharp verses that carried the frustration of a generation that felt suppressed and aban-

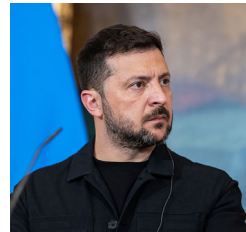
doned. Shah went on to release several popular songs which criticised corruption and social inequality in the Himalayan nation. He cut a distinctive figure in the music videos with his trademark square black sunglasses, a black blazer and black trousers. One of his best-known hits, Balidan, has amassed 14m views on YouTube. In 2022, the political newbie won Kathmandu's mayoral race by a landslide as an independent candidate, triumphing over parties which had dominated elections for decades. His tenure as mayor was marked by efforts to clean up the city, preserve indigenous heritage, and a crack-down on corruption.

Israel's Purchase Of 'Stolen' Ukrainian Grain Is Not 'Legitimate', Zelenskiy Says

IITM Bureau

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskiy said on Tuesday (April 28, 2026) that Israel's purchase of grain from occupied Ukrainian territory "stolen" by Russia "cannot be legitimate business" and that Kyiv was readying sanctions against those attempting to profit from it. "Another vessel carrying such grain has arrived at a port in Israel and is preparing to unload," Zelenskiy said on X. "This is not – and cannot be – legitimate business." "The Israeli authorities cannot be unaware of which ships are arriving at the country's ports and what cargo they are carrying," he added. Ukrainian For-

eign Minister Andrii Sybiha said on Monday that Israel's ambassador had been summoned to his ministry over what he described as Israeli inaction in allowing shipments of grain to enter the country from Russian-occupied Ukraine. Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar told Sybiha that Ukraine had provided no evidence to support allegations that the grain was "stolen". Kyiv considers all grain produced in the four regions Russia claimed as its own since invading Ukraine in 2022, and Crimea, annexed by Russia in 2014, to have been stolen by Moscow. Russia refers to the four regions



as its "new territories", but they are still internationally recognised as Ukrainian. "Russia is systematically seizing grain on temporarily occupied Ukrainian land and organizing its export through individuals linked to the occupiers," Zelenskiy said. "Such schemes violate the laws of the State of Israel itself." He added that Ukraine expected Israel to respect Ukraine and refrain from actions that undermine bilateral relations.

UNICEF Warns Afghanistan Could Lose Up To 25,000 Female Health Workers, Teachers

IITM Bureau

Afghanistan is at risk of losing more than 25,000 female teachers and health workers by 2030 if the Taliban-led country's restrictions on girls' education and women's employment are not lifted, according to a new UNICEF report released on Monday (April 27, 2026). The Taliban has banned women from most public sector jobs and limited girls to receiving an education only until the age of 12. These restrictions, according to the report, have already affected at least 1 million girls a figure that is expected to double by 2030 if nothing



changes. UNICEF Up to 20,000 female called on the Taliban teachers and 5,400 health workers could be lost by 2030, according to the report, which estimated that this figure is about 25% of Afghanistan's 2021 workforce. As many as 9,600 health workers could be lost by 2035, it added. "Afghanistan cannot afford to lose future teachers, nurses, doc-

25,000 Female Health Work-

tors, midwives, and social workers, who sustain essential services," UNICEF Executive Director Catherine Russell said. "This will be the reality if girls continue to be excluded from education." Female healthcare workers are required to attend to female patients, and female teachers are preferred for girls in gender-disaggregated schools whenever possible, the report noted. The growing decrease could have at least a AFN 5.3 billion (\$84 million) annual economic impact on Afghanistan's economy, according to UNICEF, which added that this is the equivalent of

about 0.5% of the country's gross domestic product. Afghanistan's de facto authorities should safeguard skills training and allow women to participate in the labor market, UNICEF said. The findings underscore an urgent humanitarian and developmental crisis in Afghanistan, where prolonged restrictions risk long-term damage to essential services. UNICEF emphasized that immediate policy changes are crucial to protect future generations. The crisis demands urgent global attention, as UNICEF warns consequences could worsen rapidly without reforms.

Two Pakistanis selected for astronaut training arrive in China

IITM Bureau

Two Pakistani candidates have been selected as the first foreign astronauts for China's space mission training, a government announcement said. After completing all training and evaluations, one of them will participate in a space mission as a payload specialist, becoming the first foreign astronaut on board the Tian-gong space station. The first selection of foreign astronauts for China's manned space program was completed in early April, state-run Xinhua news agency reported. Last year, China announced plans to

send an astronaut from its ally Pakistan as its first foreign guest to its space station, currently orbiting 400 km above the Earth. The agreement to send the Pakistani astronaut was signed by the China Manned Space Agency and Pakistan's Space and Upper Atmosphere Research Commission at a ceremony attended by Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif in Islamabad in February last year. The agreement included bilateral efforts to select and train Pakistani astronauts and then send some of them to China's Tian-gong space station,



which has been in orbit for nearly five years. China has been launching satellites for Pakistan for the past few years to help its ally. The Chinese space station is regarded as a rival to Russia's international space station Mir, currently in orbit. China built its space station after it was reportedly excluded from the International Space Station (ISS) over concerns that China's space programme is manned by its military, the People's Liberation Army (PLA).

Meta Platforms Boosts AI Spending Outlook to \$145 Billion Amid Legal Pressures, Investor Concerns Over Growth and Layoffs

IITM Bureau

Meta Platforms raised its annual capital spending forecast on Wednesday (April 29, 2026), signaling plans to pour billions more into artificial intelligence infrastructure even as it confronts potential losses from a global youth backlash against social media. The Facebook and Instagram parent projected 2026 capital expenditure between \$125 billion and \$145 billion, compared with its prior forecast of \$115 billion to \$135 billion. Shares of the company fell more than 6% in extended trading. Meta also warned that legal and regulatory blowback in the European Union and the U.S.



"could significantly impact our business and financial results," after years of mounting criticism about children's safety on social media. "We continue to see scrutiny on youth-related issues and have additional trials scheduled for this year in the U.S., which may ultimately result in a material loss," it said. The company is facing a rising number of teen social media bans around the globe, as well as thousands of court cases by individuals, municipalities, states and school districts that accuse it of designing addictive platforms that are harmful to children. Several high-stakes court cases are due in

the coming months, including the second New Mexico trial and a California case expected to test claims central to nearly 2,000 similar lawsuits filed by U.S. school districts. Adding to the gloom, Meta reported its first-ever quarterly decline in Daily Active People (DAP) since it started using that metric to measure user numbers across its social media platforms. It attributed the decline to internet disruptions in Iran, as well as restrictions on access to WhatsApp in Russia. Daily active people grew 4% year-over-year in the first quarter to 3.56 billion. Matt Britzman, an analyst at Hargreaves Lansdown,

said Meta's higher capital spending spooked investors but is likely overblown as it reflects more expensive memory prices rather than changes to Meta's investment plan. The results come weeks after Reuters first reported Meta's plans for sweeping layoffs, as CEO Mark Zuckerberg attempts to aggressively integrate AI into the company's workflows and reshape its workforce around the technology. The company is planning further layoffs in the second half of the year, sources have told Reuters. Meta is also installing new tracking software on U.S.-based employees' computers to capture mouse movements,

clicks and keystrokes to train its AI models, part of a broad initiative to build AI agents that can perform work tasks autonomously, Reuters reported last week. Meta Chief Financial Officer Susan Li confirmed the May layoffs on a conference call after reporting the financial results. "We don't really know what the optimal size of a company will be in the future," Li said. "I think there's a lot of change right now, with AI capabilities advancing rapidly." On the same call, Zuckerberg described seeing tiny teams use AI to make products that previously would have taken dozens of people months to finish. He said he wanted to

build "the next evolution of our company around these people," which meant investing in top-tier infrastructure, increasing rewards for heavy hitters and "streamlining teams so they aren't bigger than they need to be." Meta said its workforce at the end of March was 77,986 people, up 1% from the same period last year but down from 78,865 at the end of December. Reflecting anticipated savings, it kept the forecast for total 2026 expenses unchanged despite the projected rise in capital expenditure this year. The company reported first-quarter revenue of \$56.31 billion, beating the LSEG-compiled analysts' average esti-

mate of \$55.45 billion. It expects second-quarter revenue of \$58 billion to \$61 billion, largely in line with estimates of \$59.5 billion. But those results were eclipsed by faster growth by other tech companies. "Meta's results met expectations, but failed to impress investors, especially in the context of much stronger results from Google," said Gil Luria, managing director of D.A. Davidson. He said investors were also concerned that Meta's spending plans rose without a corresponding reduction in operating expenses. Google parent Alphabet topped Wall Street estimates for quarterly revenue and profit.

डॉलर का दबदबा, रुपये पर संकट: समझिए पूरी अर्थव्यवस्था का गणित

આયુષ અંજની

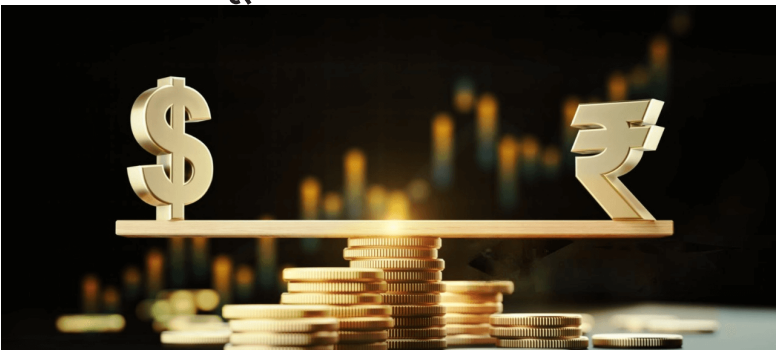
आज के समय में हम बार-बार सुन रहे हैं कि भारतीय रुपया लगातार गिर रहा है और अमेरिकी डॉलर मजबूत होता जा रहा है। यह सिर्फ एक खबर नहीं, बल्कि हमारी अर्थव्यवस्था और रोजमर्रा की ज़िंदगी से जुड़ा एक महत्वपूर्ण मुद्दा है। सवाल यह है कि आखिर डॉलर इतना प्रभावशाली क्यों है और रुपया 90 के पार क्यों चला गया? सबसे पहले समझते हैं कि अमेरिकी डॉलर इतना शक्तिशाली क्यों है। डॉलर दुनिया की सबसे बड़ी रिजर्व करेंसी है। इसका मतलब यह है कि अधिकतर देश अपने अंतरराष्ट्रीय व्यापार, तेल के भुगतान और विदेशी मुद्रा भंडार को डॉलर में रखते हैं। इसकी वजह है अमेरिका की मजबूत अर्थव्यवस्था, स्थिर व्यवस्था और वैश्विक भरोसा। जब भी दुनिया में अनिश्चितता होती है, जैसे युद्ध या आर्थिक संकट, तो निवेशक अपने पैसे को सुरक्षित रखने के लिए डॉलर खरीदते हैं। इससे डॉलर की मांग बढ़ती है और वह और मजबूत हो जाता है। अब बात करते हैं रुपये के कमजोर होने की। हाल के वर्षों में रुपया 90 प्रति डॉलर के स्तर को पार कर चुका है,

India's Education System: Cracks Beneath the Surface

Dr. Rahul Kumar

Education in India has long been seen as a powerful tool for social mobility, personal growth, and national development. From ancient centers of learning like Nalanda University to modern institutions like University Grants Commission, the country has carried a rich educational legacy. Yet, despite this strong foundation, the current state of education raises serious concerns. The system today appears to be struggling under multiple pressures, leading to a gradual decline in quality, accessibility, and relevance. One of the most visible issues is the growing commercialization of education. Private institutions are expanding rapidly, often prioritizing profit over learning. High fees and donation-based admissions have made quality education inaccessible for a large section of society. While government institutions aim to provide affordable education, they frequently suffer from poor infrastructure, outdated teaching methods, and lack of accountability. Another major concern is the outdated curriculum that fails to keep pace with changing global demands. In a world driven by innovation, digital literacy, and critical thinking, many

जो एक रिकॉर्ड गिरावट मानी जाती है। इसका सबसे बड़ा कारण है भारत का व्यापार घाटा, यानी हम आयात ज्यादा करते हैं और निर्यात कम। भारत अपनी तेल जरूरतों का लगभग 85-90% आयात करता है। जब तेल के दाम बढ़ते हैं, तो हमें ज्यादा डॉलर खर्च करने पड़ते हैं। इससे डॉलर की मांग बढ़ती है और रुपया कमजोर हो जाता है। दूसरा बड़ा कारण है विदेशी निवेश का व्यवहारा जल्द अमेरिका में ब्याज दरें बढ़ती हैं, तो वैश्विक निवेशक अपना पैसा भारत जैसे देशों से निकालकर अमेरिका में निवेश करने लगते हैं। इससे भारत से डॉलर बाहर जाता है और रुपये पर दबाव बढ़ता है। अब एक महत्वपूर्ण सवाल—क्या रुपया और डॉलर कभी बराबर हो सकते हैं? इसका जवाब है, नहीं। किसी भी मुद्रा की कीमत उस देश की अर्थव्यवस्था, उत्पादकता और वैश्विक मांग पर निर्भर करती है। अमेरिका की अर्थव्यवस्था अभी भी भारत से बड़ी है और डॉलर की मांग पूरी दुनिया में है, जबकि रुपया मुख्यतः घरेलू मुद्रा है। इसलिए दोनों का बराबर होना संभव नहीं है। यहाँ बाजार की भूमिका बहुत अहम हो जाती है। विदेशी मुद्रा बाजार (फॉरेक्स मार्केट) यह तय करता है

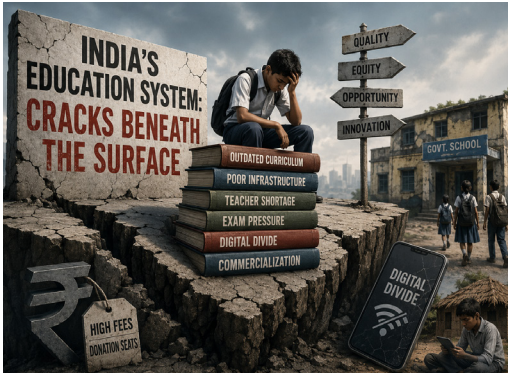


कि 1 डॉलर की कीमत कितनी होगी। अगर बाजार में डॉलर की मांग बढ़ेगी तो रुपया गिरेगा, और अगर डॉलर की आपूर्ति बढ़ेगी या भारत में निवेश आएगा तो रुपया मजबूत हो सकता है। यानी मुद्रा का मूल्य पूरी तरह मांग और आपूर्ति पर निर्भर करता है। अब इसका असर आम आदमी पर समझते हैं। जब रुपया गिरता है, तो सबसे पहले महंगाई बढ़ती है। पेट्रोल और डीजल महंगे हो जाते हैं क्योंकि तेल का आयात महंगा हो जाता है। इसके अलावा मोबाइल, इलेक्ट्रॉनिक्स और अन्य आयातित सामान के दाम भी बढ़ जाते हैं। जो छात्र विदेश में पढ़ाई करना चाहते हैं, उनके लिए फीस और खर्च काफी बढ़ जाते हैं। यानी रुपये की गिरावट का सीधा असर हर व्यक्ति की जेब पर पड़ता है।

हालांकि, रुपये का गिरना हमेशा नुकसानदायक नहीं होता। जब रुपया कमजोर होता है, तो भारत के निर्यात सस्ते हो जाते हैं, जिससे निर्यातकों को फायदा होता है। खासकर आईटी सेक्टर और निर्यात-आधारित उद्योगों को इसका लाभ मिलता है। लेकिन अगर आयात ज्यादा और निर्यात कम हो, तो कुल मिलाकर नुकसान ज्यादा होता है।

अब सवाल है कि सरकार क्या कर सकती है? सरकार और भारतीय रिजर्व बैंक कुछ कदम उठा सकते हैं, जैसे विदेशी मुद्रा भंडार का उपयोग करके डॉलर की आपूर्ति बढ़ाना, ब्याज दरों को समायोजित करना और विदेशी निवेश को आकर्षित करना। लंबे समय में भारत को अपनी मैनुफैक्चरिंग बढ़ानी होगी, निर्यात को मजबूत करना होगा और तेल

आयात पर निर्भरता कम करने होगी। अगर पिछले वर्षों का रुझान देखें, तो 1991 में रुपये लगभग ₹17 प्रति डॉलर था, जो आज ₹90 के ऊपर पहुंच गया है। यह एक धीरे-धीरे होने वाली गिरावट है जो दिखाती है कि डॉलर की वैश्विक ताकत लगातार बढ़ी है। अंत में, यद्यपि समझना जरूरी है कि डॉलर का मजबूत होना और रुपये का कमजोर होना एक वैश्विक प्रणाली का हिस्सा है। लेकिन अगर भारत अपने अर्थव्यवस्था को मजबूत बनाता है, निर्यात बढ़ाता है और वैश्विक बाजार में अपनी स्थिति सुधाराता है, तो रुपये को स्थिर और मजबूत बनाया जा सकता है। सरल शब्दों में, मजबूत अर्थव्यवस्था ही मजबूत मुद्रा की सबसे बड़ी ताकत होती है।



cine, or government services. As a result, students often grow up under constant pressure to meet societal expectations rather than discovering their individual strengths, interests, and capabilities. Creative fields, vocational education, sports, performing arts, and entrepreneurship continue to receive comparatively less importance, even though these sectors hold immense potential in the modern economy. This narrow understanding of success not only limits opportunities for young people but also creates an environment where the fear of failure becomes more dominant than the joy of learning. At the same time, many educational institutions focus heavily on placements, advertisements, and infrastructure branding while neglecting essential aspects such as research culture, innovation, ethical learning, and emotional well-being of students. Education should ideally nurture curiosity, confidence, independent thinking,

and social responsibility, but the current system often turns it into a mechanical process centered around examinations and competition. The need of the hour is not merely policy reform but a transformation in mindset at every level—among policymakers, teachers, parents, and students alike. Equal emphasis must be placed on values, practical learning, critical thinking, and skill development so that education becomes more meaningful and connected to real-life challenges. Unless India succeeds in creating an inclusive, balanced, and future-oriented education system that values learning over scoring and growth over mere qualification, the deeper structural problems will continue to weaken the true purpose of education in society. If these challenges remain unaddressed, the education system risks producing qualified individuals on paper but not empowered citizens capable of shaping the nation's future.

Spirituality in Education: A Holistic Path to Nurturing Mind, Body, and Soul

Dr. Rajnesh Kumar Pandey



In an age dominated by rapid technological advancement and intense competition, the concept of spirituality in education may seem out of place. However, it is becoming increasingly relevant as societies across the world confront complex challenges such as environmental degradation, social inequality, mental health crises, and political instability. These issues highlight the urgent need for an education system that goes beyond textbooks and examinations to address the deeper dimensions of human life values, purpose, and meaning.

Spirituality in education is not confined to religious teachings. Instead, it encompasses a broader understanding of self-awareness, inner growth, and a sense of connection with others and the world. It encourages students to reflect on their lives, develop empathy, and cultivate resilience. By integrating spiritual values into education, institutions can nurture emotionally intelligent individuals who are not only academically competent but also ethically grounded.

A holistic approach to education focuses on the balanced development of the mind, body, and spirit. Intellectual growth remains a cornerstone, with emphasis on critical thinking, creativity, and problem-solving. However, spirituality enriches this process by fostering curiosity and a genuine love for learning. Students begin to see education not merely as a means to achieve grades but as a journey of discovery and personal growth. Equally vital is physical well-being. Schools that promote sports, yoga, and healthy lifestyles contribute significantly to students' overall development. Practices such as yoga and meditation help students build concentration, reduce stress, and enhance self-awareness. They also encourage a deeper connection between the mind and body, leading to improved mental and physical health.

The spiritual dimension plays a crucial role in emotional and social development as well. Values such as kindness, compassion, gratitude, humility, and service are central to spiritual learning. These values help students build meaningful relationships, manage emotions effectively, and develop a sense of responsibility toward society. In a world often marked by stress and competition, such qualities are essential for maintaining balance and inner peace. Educational institutions can adopt various strategies to integrate spirituality into learning. Mindfulness and meditation practices can be included in daily routines to enhance focus and emotional regulation. A value-based curriculum can encourage ethical thinking and responsible decision-making. Service learning and community engagement can instill a sense of purpose and social responsibility among students. Additionally, arts, music, and creative expression provide powerful avenues for self-discovery and emotional expression, while reflection and gratitude practices help students develop a positive outlook on life. In conclusion, integrating spirituality with modern education offers a transformative approach to student development. It prepares individuals not only to succeed professionally but also to lead meaningful, balanced, and compassionate lives. As the world continues to evolve, the need for such holistic education becomes even more critical, shaping future generations into thoughtful leaders and responsible global citizens.

Photo of the Month



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India-New Zealand FTA Opens Global Doors For Ayush Systems, Creates Mobility Pathways For Wellness Professionals

IITM Bureau

The newly concluded India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) is set to give a major global push to India's traditional medicine systems, placing Ayush systems at the centre of a new framework for international cooperation and market access. The agreement, signed by Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and New Zealand's Trade Minister Todd McClay on April 30, 2026 marks a significant step in expanding India's wellness footprint globally while strengthening bilateral economic ties. A key highlight of the FTA is the inclusion of a dedicated Health and Traditional Medicine

Annex, a first-of-its-kind provision in any trade pact between the two countries. This framework formally recognises India's traditional systems under Ministry of Ayush – including Ayurveda, Yoga, Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, So-wa-Rigpa and Homoeopathy – as globally relevant healthcare practices, alongside indigenous Māori health traditions. The agreement is expected to open new markets for Indian wellness services and institutions, facilitating greater engagement in areas such as preventive healthcare, medical value travel, and integrative medicine. The framework is expected to boost international collaborations, research



partnerships and institutional linkages in the wellness sector. One of the most notable provisions is the creation of structured mobility pathways for Indian professionals. The FTA introduces a dedicated visa quota that will allow Ayush practitioners and yoga instructors to work in New Zealand for extended periods, expanding employment opportunities and enhancing India's posi-

tion as a global supplier of skilled wellness professionals. The Ayush Ministry said the pact also lays the groundwork for deeper cooperation in education, training, standards development and traditional knowledge systems, integrating ancient practices into a modern trade and regulatory framework. The agreement is being seen as a major step in positioning Ayush as a pillar of global healthcare, advancing India's vision of promoting holistic, sustainable and people-centric health solutions worldwide. Officials believe the agreement will further strengthen cultural exchanges and encourage wider global acceptance of traditional healthcare systems rooted in natural healing and wellness practices. Experts also noted that increased international cooperation could attract investments in wellness tourism, research, and skill development, while creating new opportunities for Indian practitioners, educational institutions, and healthcare enterprises in emerging global markets focused on holistic and preventive healthcare solutions.

NITI Aayog Launches Roadmap For Next Phase Of India's Digital Public Infrastructure Journey

IITM Bureau

NITI Aayog has launched a strategic roadmap that charts the next phase of India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) journey as a driver of inclusive, non-linear, and productivity-led growth, an official statement said on Tuesday (April 28, 2026). The 'DPI@2047 for Viksit Bharat' marks an important evolution in India's digital journey from digital inclusion alone to enabling capability, productivity, and opportunity at scale.



According to a NITI Aayog statement, the roadmap, developed in partnership with EkStep Foundation and Deloitte, sets out a two-phase path for India's digital transformation: DPI 2.0 (2025–2035) to drive livelihood-led growth at scale, followed by DPI 3.0 (2035–2047) to enable broad-based prosperity. The immediate focus is DPI 2.0. Under DPI 2.0, the roadmap identifies eight sectoral transformations to address structural bottlenecks across MSMEs, agriculture, education, and health, while strengthening systemic enablers such as credit, decentralised energy, and benefit delivery. To translate intent into outcomes, it outlines

four execution imperatives: district-led demand aggregation, scaling technology entrepreneurship, leveraging AI, and deploying cross-sector unlocks through better data use, digital transactions, stronger human capacity, and the democratisation of AI, said the statement. At its core, DPI 2.0 is about extending India's digital rails beyond identity, payments, and welfare into the engines of livelihoods, productivity, and market access.

It reflects a larger shift in how growth will be created in the years ahead: not simply by inventing new technologies, but by building the connective infrastructure that allows innovation to work together, travel faster, and reach more people. By combining open digital infrastructure with trusted data flows and ecosystem-led innovation, the roadmap creates the conditions for technologies such as AI to diffuse at scale across citizens and small enterprises. Suman Bery, outgoing Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog, said the focus has shifted from GDP to productivity. Higher quality employment, stronger incomes, and better living standards depend on rising productivity.

India Extends Rs 30 Billion Currency Swap Support to Maldives Under SAARC Framework, Reinforcing Regional Economic Stability

IITM Bureau

Bank of India and the Maldives Monetary Authority. The settlement reflects the Maldives government's commitment to meeting its financial obligations, the Maldives Foreign Ministry said. The Rs 30 billion facility has been released under the INR Swap Window of the 'Framework on Currency Swap Arrangement for SAARC Countries, 2024-2027'. The agreement was signed between the RBI and the MMA during President Mohamed Muizzu's state visit to New Delhi in October 2024. Accord-

ing to the Maldives Foreign Ministry, the facility will support the government's broader strategy to reinforce economic stability amid the evolving situation in West Asia. The INR Swap Window under the framework includes favourable terms aimed at improving accessibility and effectiveness for the recipient country. Since the inception of the SAARC Swap Framework in 2012, the RBI has extended aggregate swap support worth \$1.1 billion to the Maldives. The Indian High Commission noted that the cur-



rency swap arrangement has become an important element in ensuring financial stability for the Maldives, particularly during periods of external economic pressure. The Indian High Commission reiterated that the Maldives remains a vital partner under India's 'Neighbourhood First' policy and Vi-

sion MAHASAGAR. "India, as a friendly neighbour, has always been the 'first responder' for the Maldives," the statement said. The Maldives Foreign Ministry welcomed India's continued support, calling the approval of the RS 30 billion swap facility a testament to the enduring part-

Cabinet approves ₹28,840 crore Modified UDAN scheme; to develop 100 airports, 200 helipads

IITM Bureau

The cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on 25 March, approved the launch and implementation of the Regional Connectivity Scheme (RCS)–Modified Ude Desh ka Aam Naagrik (UDAN) for 10 years, with a total outlay of ₹28,840 crore backed by government budgetary support. Under the scheme, which will be in place from financial year (FY) 2026–27 to FY 2035–36, the government will develop 100 airports/airstrips. "Under the Modified UDAN Scheme, it is proposed to develop 100 airports from existing unserved airstrips to enhance regional connectivity,

in line with the Viksit Bharat 2047 vision of infrastructure expansion and transforming India into a globally competitive aviation ecosystem, with a total outlay of ₹12,159 crore over the next eight years," a statement issued by the government read. "It will be a boost to economic growth, trade and tourism in tier-2 and tier-3 cities, support affordable air travel (help in) improved emergency response and healthcare access in remote and hilly regions, greater viability and sustainability for regional aerodromes and airline operators, promotion of the indigenous aerospace sector under Atmanir-

bhar Bharat and progress towards the Viksit Bharat 2047 goal," the statement further added. The first UDAN scheme (UDAN 1.0) was launched in October 2016 and took off on April 27, 2017, with the objective of making air travel affordable and strengthening connectivity to tier-2 and tier-3 cities. UDAN 2.0 was launched in 2018, UDAN 3.0 in 2019, and UDAN 4.0 in 2020. A series of UDAN 5 was launched starting April 2023. Thereafter, UDAN 5.1 was launched in May 2023, UDAN 5.2 in July the same year, UDAN 5.3 in January 2024, UDAN 5.4 in August 2024, and UDAN 5.5 was launched in February last year.

Chandrababu Naidu, Ashwini Vaishnav Lay Foundation For Google Cloud AI Hub In Vizag

IITM Bureau

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, along with Union Minister for Electronics and Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnav, laid the foundation stone for the Google Cloud India AI Hub in Visakhapatnam on April 28, 2026, marking the beginning of a new era in the state's technological journey. Google is going to invest \$15 billion in the project, making it one of the largest foreign direct investments (FDIs) in India's history. The data centre with a total capacity of 1 gigawatt will be developed across nearly 600 acres in Tharluwada, Adavivaram, and Rambilli



regions. Speaking at the groundbreaking ceremony, Chandrababu Naidu urged Google and its partners in the project, AdaniConneX and Airtel Nxtra, to complete the project for inauguration by September 2028. He assured all the help from the state government for the early completion of the project. He termed Google's arrival as a game-changer not just for Visakhapatnam, but for the entire state

of Andhra Pradesh. He recalled that 30 years ago, when he laid the foundation for Cyberabad as an IT City, it evolved into a hub for wealth creation. Stating that this will be the largest data centre in Asia, the Chief Minister said Andhra Pradesh will emerge as the AI data gateway for the nation. "Google, which began as a search engine, is now transforming into a growth engine for India. While

everyone typically searches on Google, in this instance, Google searched and chose Andhra Pradesh," he said. He exuded confidence that with the arrival of Google, the youth of Visakhapatnam will gain access to large-scale employment opportunities. Chandrababu Naidu also announced that Bhogapuram International Airport will be inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in July. Union Minister Vaishnav noted that as a country, India missed out on many technology cycles and that the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi is that India should take a lead in the new cycle of technologies.

nership between the two countries. It also underscored New Delhi's commitment to regional financial cooperation through the SAARC framework. The currency swap arrangement allows the Maldives to access foreign exchange in times of liquidity stress without relying solely on commercial borrowings, helping it manage balance-of-payment pressures and maintain macroeconomic stability. For India, the facility is part of a broader strategy to strengthen economic ties with South Asian neighbours and counterbal-

ance growing external influence in the region. Officials in Male said the latest swap will provide immediate relief to the country's foreign exchange reserves and support its efforts to stabilise the economy as global uncertainties persist. With West Asia facing renewed geopolitical volatility, the timely assistance is seen as crucial for maintaining investor confidence and ensuring smooth external payments. The latest financial assistance is expected to strengthen bilateral trust and reinforce regional economic

resilience amid ongoing global uncertainties. Analysts believe the move will help the Maldives maintain fiscal stability, support essential imports, and safeguard investor confidence during a challenging economic period. The development also highlights India's continued commitment to regional cooperation, economic assistance, and long-term strategic partnerships in South Asia. The support further reflects India's proactive regional diplomacy and its emphasis on ensuring sustainable economic

Medical Commission Notifies Draft Amendments To Ease Registration Norms For Armed Forces Doctors

IITM Bureau

The National Medical Commission (NMC) has proposed amendment to simplify registration norms for doctors serving in the Armed Forces Medical Services (AFMS), addressing challenges caused by their frequent transfers and operational responsibilities. In a draft notified on April 7, the commission suggested changes to the Registration of Medical Practitioners and Licence to Practice Medicine Regulations. The proposal allows AFMS doctors to remain registered with a single State Medical Council throughout their service, instead of obtaining multiple registrations across different states. The move

Nadda Highlights Shift To Holistic Healthcare In Battle Against Non-Communicable Diseases

IITM Bureau

Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda on Tuesday (April 21 2026) highlighted India's shift towards a holistic healthcare approach to tackle the growing burden of non-communicable diseases (NCDs), stressing the need to move from prevention to comprehensive care. He was addressing a session titled "Addressing Non-Communicable Diseases in India: From Preventive to Care" during the Civil Services Day celebrations in New Delhi. Nadda said nearly 60 per cent of deaths in India are linked to NCDs, underlining the urgency of strengthening early detection, infrastructure, and public awareness. He noted that since 2017, over 41.5 crore people

World Homoeopathy Day 2026 Concludes with

IITM Bureau

The two-day World Homoeopathy Day 2026 celebrations concluded on April 12, 2026, in New Delhi, with a strong focus on integrating homoeopathy into mainstream healthcare, as policymakers, researchers, and practitioners outlined a forward-looking roadmap for the sector. Organised under the theme “Homoeopathy for Sustainable Health” with the vision of “Infinite Possibilities,” the convention at Vigyan Bhawan brought together senior officials from the Ministry of Ayush,

recognizes the distinct nature of military medical service. AFMS doctors are often deployed at short notice to remote or sensitive locations and are required to move across states depending on operational needs. Their duties include medical support during conflicts, disaster relief operations, and emergency evacuations. These conditions make repeated state-wise registrations impractical and administratively burdensome. Currently, doctors must register in each state where they practice, leading to duplication of paperwork and payment of fees. The NMC noted that such requirements place unnecessary

have been screened for hypertension and 41.3 crore for diabetes, while screenings for oral cancer and breast cancer have reached 35.3 crore and 16.5 crore respectively. Highlighting healthcare expansion, he said the country now has 880 medical colleges and 23 AIIMS, alongside an allocation of 64,000 crore to bridge gaps between primary and secondary healthcare systems. Emphasizing preventive healthcare, the minister pointed out that nearly 70 per cent of NCD risk factors are linked to lifestyle choices. He cited government initiatives like Eat Right India and Fit India Movement, which promote healthier diets and physical activity. He also high-

experts and representatives of leading institutions. The discussions centred on clinical advancements, policy frameworks, research priorities and the expanding role of homeopathy in delivering accessible and patient-centric healthcare. Addressing the valedictory session, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Ayush, Alarmelmangai D., reiterated the government's commitment to strengthening homeopathy within the broader healthcare ecosystem. She highlighted its potential



strain on AFMS personnel, whose postings are dictated by service exigencies rather than personal preference. Under the proposed amendment, doctors joining AFMS can choose a State Medical Council for registration at the time of entry into service. This single registration will permit them to practice across all states and Union Territories during their tenure. The amendment also allows them to register additional qualifications with the same council, ensuring nationwide validity. To ensure continuity of practice, the proposal states that licences of AFMS doctors will not become inactive due to delays in renewal. Instead, the office of the Director General of AFMS will coordinate with State Medical Councils by submitting practitioner details and

renewal records annually. The draft also outlines accountability mechanisms. In cases of alleged professional misconduct, the State Medical Council where the doctor is registered will have jurisdiction, based on inputs from the council where the issue arises. At the same time, AFMS doctors will remain subject to disciplinary provisions under Armed Forces laws. According to the NMC, the amendment aims to reduce administrative hurdles while maintaining professional standards ultimately enhancing efficiency, mobility, and quality healthcare delivery in critical national service conditions across India.

Defence Secretary Opens Robotic Orthopaedic System At Delhi Cantt Hospital

IITM Bureau

Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh on April 23, inaugurated the Robotic Orthopaedic System and Maternity Operation Theatre at Cantonment General Hospital here and highlighted the government's commitment to ensuring high-quality medical services for residents. The new facilities inaugurated by the Defence Secretary, in the presence of Director General, Defence Estates, Shobha Gupta, will aid advanced healthcare services for the residents of the Cantonment and neighbouring municipal areas, said an official statement. The Director General of Defence Estates lauded the initiative, noting that such developments will sig-

IITM Bureau
The Madhya Pradesh Council of Ministers on April 22, approved the establishment of accommodation facilities for patients' relatives within the campuses of selected medical colleges in the state, to be facilitated through philanthropic organizations. These organisations will establish such 'relatives' rest houses' using their own financial resources; the state government will not provide any financial assistance for this purpose. The fees to be charged by the organisations for these services will be determined by a committee constituted by the state government. This proposed arrangement will pro-

nificantly strengthen healthcare delivery systems within cantonment areas and contribute to overall community welfare. The newly-launched Robotic Orthopaedic System represents a major technological upgrade, enabling precision-driven surgical procedures, reduced recovery times and improved patient outcomes. Equipped with a cutting-edge robotic system, the unit is expected to enhance the hospital's capability in handling complex orthopaedic cases with greater accuracy and efficiency, said the statement. Also, the Maternity Operation Theatre has been designed to provide comprehensive and safe surgical care for

vide patients' relatives with better accommodation facilities at affordable rates, thereby improving their mental well-being. This, in turn, will have a direct positive impact on the hospital's overall management and ensure smoother operations. Patients from distant regions often seek treatment at hospitals affiliated with medical colleges. They are invariably accompanied by their relatives. Many of these relatives, unable to bear the financial burden of arranging accommodation outside the hospital premises, end up sleeping within the hospital campus itself. This places an additional strain on the

hospital's sanitation and hygiene systems, while also leaving the relatives without a comfortable place to stay. This situation has an indirect impact on the hospital's administrative management and the interactions between patients/relatives and the hospital staff, thereby adversely affecting the hospitals' overall functioning. The Council of Ministers has approved an allocation of Rs 5,479 crore under the Department of Public Health and Medical Education to provide advanced medical services across the state, upgrade existing medical colleges, and establish a new Government Medical College in Mandla.



expectant mothers. On the occasion, a brief presentation was also made on the planned upgrades at Cantonment General Hospital, which includes a Dialysis Centre, Central Sterile Services Department (CSSD), ICU upgrades, and laboratory expansion over the next three months. Over the next one year, facilities such as a Paediatric ICU, Neonatal ICU, CT Scan, MRI, Cancer Screening Unit, High Dependency Unit, Multispecialty Ward, and Surgical ICU are also planned to be developed to fur-

ther enhance health-care services, said the statement. In a separate development, the Indian Army's Central Command, Military Hospital, Jabalpur, conducted a Mental Health Awareness Programme for Officers and Junior Commissioned Officers of HQ 1 Signals Training Centre. The programme emphasized stress management, intervention, counselling support, resilience building, and reducing stigma associated with mental health issues among personnel.

highlighted the role of telemedicine through the eSanjeevani platform, which has facilitated over 46.4 crore consultations, particularly benefiting rural populations. Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava stressed a multi-pronged strategy to combat NCDs, focusing on prevention, behavioral change, and community participation. She flagged rising obesity levels citing NFHS-5 data showing 24 per cent of women and 23 per cent of men are overweight

or obese and called for urgent dietary and lifestyle interventions. The government, she added, is promoting awareness through initiatives such as the “75×25” campaign and Swasth Nari, Sashakt Pariwar Abhiyan, alongside school and workplace wellness programmes. Experts at the session also underscored the importance of early screening and sustained preventive efforts to reduce the long-term disease burden in the country.

in promoting sustainable and integrative healthcare systems across the country. The event began with a welcome address by Dr Sunil S. Ramteke of the Central Council for Research in Homoeopathy (CCRH). Overviews of the deliberations were later presented by Dr Pralay Sharma of the National Institute of Homoeopathy (NIH), Dr Subhash Kaushik, Director General of CCRH, and Dr Tarkeshwar Jain, Chairperson of the National Commission for Homoeopathy (NCH), outlining key scientific discussions and



policy insights from the two-day event. The convention also recognised notable contributions to the field, with honours conferred on Dr Nandini Kumar, Padma Shri awardee Dr V.K. Gupta and Dr Kalyan Bannerjee. Around 90 students, including STSH and MD

new remedies including *Cassia fistula*, and agro-homoeopathy in agriculture. A multidisciplinary discussion involving experts from modern medicine explored collaborative approaches to patient care. On the second day, the focus shifted to policy, regulation and global integration. Key sessions examined the expansion of community healthcare services and strengthening the National Register of Homoeopathy to enhance transparency. Experts also stressed the need for drug standardization and pharmacovigi-

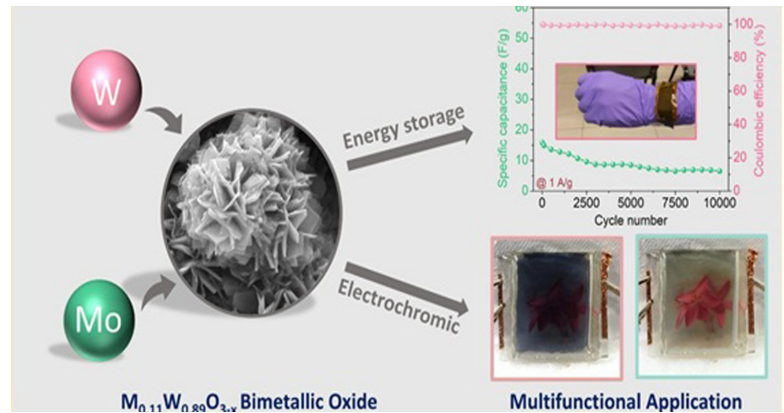
lance to ensure patient safety. Discussions further explored homoeopathy's place in the WHO Traditional Medicine Strategy, highlighting both global opportunities and challenges. Emerging areas such as veterinary applications and the use of scientific innovation to address issues like drug resistance were also deliberated. A high-level session led by the Ministry of Ayush and CCRH outlined strategic priorities and the future direction of research and institutional development in homoeopathy.

Indian Scientists Develop Smart Oxide That Stores Energy And Shows Charge Level Through Colour Change

IITM Bureau

Scientists from Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences have developed a novel smart material that can both store energy and visually indicate its charge level by changing colour, marking a significant breakthrough in next-generation energy storage technology. The development was announced on April 28, 2026. The research team, led by Ashutosh Kumar Singh, has created an oxygen-deficient bimetallic oxide composed of molybdenum and tungsten. The material uniquely overcomes a long-standing limitation in electronics, where devices typically either store energy or display information

but rarely both. In this innovation, the material changes colour based on its charge state appearing blue when charged and turning transparent when discharged allowing users to instantly gauge the energy level without additional sensors or displays. Researchers explained that the key to this functionality lies in the oxide's "oxygen-deficient" structure. By deliberately creating vacancies in the atomic lattice, the team enabled easier movement of ions within the material. As ions move during charging and discharging, they simultaneously alter the material's electronic structure, resulting in a visible colour shift



that acts as a real-time and display technologies. When tested as a supercapacitor electrode, the material exhibited high energy storage capacity and stability, maintaining performance over 10,000 charge-discharge cycles. It also proved durable under mechanical stress and varying environmental conditions. In practical demonstrations, devices built using the mate-

TRAI Releases Consultation Paper On Expansion Of Public Wi-Fi Networks

IITM Bureau

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India released a consultation paper on April 28, 2026, titled "Proliferation of Public Wi-Fi Networks in India," with the objective of accelerating the expansion of public internet infrastructure across the country. The paper reviews the existing regulatory framework and identifies key challenges affecting the expansion of public Wi-Fi networks. It also seeks suggestions from stakeholders on measures to accelerate deployment and improve accessibility. According to TRAI, the consultation paper examines global best practices by analysing public Wi-Fi ecosys-

tems in other countries and drawing key lessons for India. It also assesses the current status of public Wi-Fi in India, including deployment trends and demand patterns, while identifying bottlenecks that have slowed its growth. The paper outlines the roles of various stakeholders, including Central and State governments, local bodies, telecom service providers, internet service providers, and private entities, in developing sustainable public Wi-Fi models across rural and urban areas, as well as high-footfall locations. Key operational aspects such as authorisation, authentication, roaming, and billing systems within

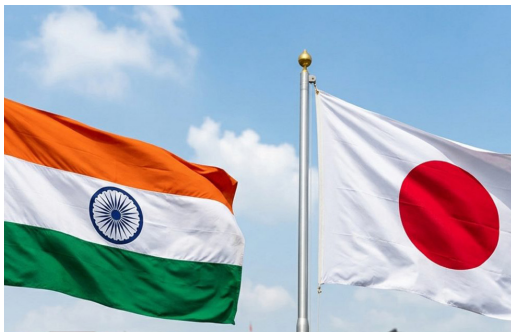


the public Wi-Fi ecosystem have also been examined. In addition, TRAI has analysed potential revenue models both direct and indirect to ensure the long-term viability of public Wi-Fi services in India. The consultation paper has been made available on TRAI's official website. Stakeholders have been invited to submit written comments by May 25, 2026, and counter-comments by June 8, 2026.

India, Japan Hold First AI Strategic Dialogue In Mumbai To Boost Tech Cooperation

IITM Bureau

India and Japan on Tuesday (April 21, 2026) held their inaugural Artificial Intelligence (AI) Strategic Dialogue in Mumbai, marking a significant step toward strengthening bilateral cooperation in emerging technologies and digital innovation. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said that the dialogue was co-chaired by Amit A. Shukla, MEA Joint Secretary (Cyber Diplomacy) and Hanada Takahiro, Deputy Assistant Minister for Cyber Security at Japan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Officials from various ministries, departments, and agencies of both countries participated, along



with representatives from the AI industry. During the discussions, both sides explored opportunities for collaboration across the entire AI ecosystem, focusing on co-creation, policy alignment, and the development of industry-oriented AI solutions. The MEA said that talks aimed at fostering a robust, innovative, and trustworthy AI environment in both countries. The MEA said that key areas of cooperation

included enhancing international mobility of AI professionals, promoting joint research through academic and industry exchanges, and strengthening collaboration in AI governance and policy frameworks at global platforms. The dialogue builds on the India-Japan AI Cooperation Initiative announced during the visit of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Japan in August 2025. The initiative forms a

core part of the broader India-Japan Joint Vision for the Next Decade, which seeks to deepen ties in technology, innovation, and strategic sectors. "Both countries reaffirmed their commitment to jointly navigate the challenges and opportunities over the next decade in the field of AI, to help attain respective domestic goals, and to bring the next generation closer together," the MEA added. They also agreed to hold the next round of the AI Strategic Dialogue in Japan at mutually convenient dates. The dialogue is expected to accelerate innovation, strengthen digital partnerships, and create new opportunities for startups, and researchers.

India Accelerates Green Energy Push, Targets 500 GW Capacity By 2030: Pralhad Joshi

IITM Bureau

India is rapidly advancing its clean energy transition, with a target of achieving 500 gigawatts (GW) of installed power capacity by 2030, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Wednesday (April 29, 2026). Speaking to media on the sidelines of the 'Resilient Futures Summit 2026' in the national capital, Joshi highlighted that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the country has made significant strides in the renewable energy sector. "India has already achieved its goal of sourcing 50 per cent of its electricity from non-fossil fuel sources five years ahead of schedule demonstrating the government's



ability to surpass its own targets," Joshi stated. "Nearly 30 per cent of India's electricity is now generated from a mix of renewable sources, including wind, solar, battery storage, and pumped storage," he noted. He added that during peak demand periods, almost two-thirds of the country's power requirement was recently met through renewable energy, underscoring both increased generation capacity and improved transmission efficiency. Joshi de-

scribed this progress as a major "success story" for India. "India is aggressively expanding its energy capacity and is on track to meet key milestones by 2027," he stated. "While substantial capacity has already been installed, significant work remains, which the government aims to complete through a utility-led model," Joshi stated. He also underlined India's remarkable progress in solar and green energy over the past few years, adding

that several large-scale projects are currently underway. Meanwhile, earlier this month, Joshi said that India has recorded its best-ever annual increase in wind energy capacity with a historic 6.1 GW addition during 2025-26. "India currently ranks fourth globally in wind energy, with more than 56.1 GW installed capacity and an additional 28 GW under implementation, the Union Minister said in his address at the foundation day event of the Wind Independent Power Producers Association (WIPPA) on April 22. The government reaffirmed its commitment to sustainable development to strengthen India's clean energy future.

AI Reveals Hidden Ocean Current, Marking a Major Breakthrough in Climate and Marine Science

JYOTI B

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has once again demonstrated its transformative power—this time beneath the surface of the world's oceans. In a groundbreaking scientific development, researchers have used AI-driven technology to detect hidden ocean currents that were previously impossible to observe with traditional methods. The discovery is being hailed as a major advancement in oceanography and climate science, with experts believing it could sig-

nificantly improve weather forecasting, climate prediction, and marine conservation efforts. Oceans cover more than 70 percent of Earth's surface and play a crucial role in regulating global temperatures, weather systems, and biodiversity. Ocean currents act like giant conveyor belts, transporting heat, nutrients, and carbon across the planet. However, many smaller and deeper current systems have remained invisible due to technological limitations and the complexity of ocean behavior.

Using advanced machine learning models and satellite data, scientists were able to identify subtle movement patterns hidden beneath the ocean surface. The AI system analyzed enormous volumes of data collected from satellites, underwater sensors, and climate observations, detecting relationships and flow structures that human researchers and conventional computer models had failed to notice. According to researchers, these newly discovered currents could help explain several

long-standing mysteries related to climate behavior, marine ecosystems, and sudden weather changes. Some of these currents appear to influence the formation of storms, heat distribution in the oceans, and even the melting rate of polar ice caps. One of the most remarkable aspects of the discovery is the speed and efficiency with which AI processed the information. Traditional ocean analysis methods often require years of observation and interpretation. AI, however, can rapidly

analyze massive datasets and identify patterns in a fraction of the time. Scientists say this could revolutionize the future of Earth science research. The findings are expected to strengthen climate prediction models. Since oceans absorb more than 90 percent of excess heat trapped by greenhouse gases, understanding hidden ocean circulation is essential for predicting global warming trends accurately. Improved current mapping may also help governments and environmental agencies prepare better

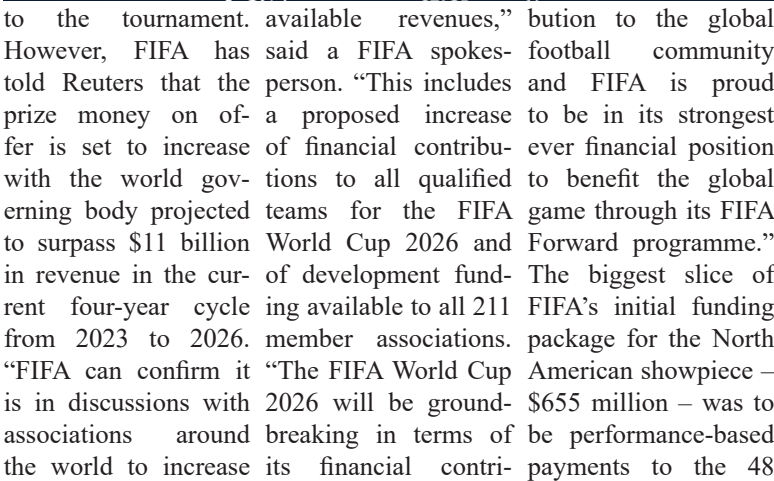
for hurricanes, floods, droughts, and rising sea levels. Marine researchers are equally excited about the implications for ocean biodiversity. Ocean currents influence the migration patterns of fish, whales, and other marine species. By understanding these currents more clearly, scientists can improve conservation strategies and better protect vulnerable ecosystems. The breakthrough also highlights the growing role of Artificial Intelligence in scientific discovery. From healthcare and

astronomy to climate science and environmental monitoring, AI is increasingly becoming a powerful tool for solving complex global challenges. Experts believe that AI-assisted research could lead to faster breakthroughs in fields where massive amounts of data are difficult for humans to analyze alone. While the discovery is still being studied further, scientists describe it as a major milestone in humanity's understanding of the oceans. Researchers from multiple countries are now collaborating to expand

the project and use AI for deeper exploration of Earth's least understood regions. As climate change continues to impact the planet, the ability to "see" hidden ocean behavior may prove crucial in protecting the future of humanity and the environment. What remained invisible for centuries is now becoming visible, thanks to the remarkable capabilities of Artificial Intelligence. AI is not just helping scientists explore the oceans—it is helping humanity better understand the future of our planet.

Lionel Messi Acquires Spanish Club UE Cornellà

FIFA is in discussions with national associations to increase prize money for all 48 teams participating in the 2026 World Cup, soccer's global governing body said on Sunday (April 26 2026). The proposal must be approved at Tuesday's FIFA Council meeting being held ahead of the 76th FIFA Congress in Vancouver. In December, FIFA said prize money for this year's World Cup would be 50% higher than for the previous edition at \$655 million after agreeing a record \$727 million financial contribution



participating nations. FIFA's December announcement on prize money said the champions would take home \$50 million and the runners-up \$33 million while the 16 nations that failed to advance from the initial group phase were set to earn \$9 million. FIFA's 2025 annual report said 93% of its total budgeted revenue had already been contracted by the end of 2025 thanks to the success of the inaugural 32-team Club World Cup held in the United States last year. The 2026 World Cup runs from June 11 to July 19 in the U.S., Mexico and Canada.

Lionel Messi has made a significant move into football ownership by acquiring UE Cornellà, a Catalan side currently playing in Spain's fourth tier, the Tercera Federación. Messi's investment highlights a deeper connection to Catalonia and a long-term plan to develop local talent. In an official statement released on April 17, 2024, the purpose of the acquisition was made clear: "With this operation, Messi strengthens his close relationship with Barcelona and his commitment to developing sport and local talent in Catalonia."

This connection dates back to his time as an FC Barcelona player and has remained strong over the years.” Founded in 1951, Cornellà is currently enjoying a strong season, sitting third in their group and just five points behind leaders CE Manresa. They have already secured a spot in the promotion play-offs. Messi is expected to support the club with a structured investment plan, focusing on enhancing the youth academy and helping the team progress to higher levels of Spanish football. A major reason behind Messi’s decision is Cornellà’s reputation as a talent hub. The club has consistently developed players who have gone on to succeed at the top level. The announcement emphasised this legacy: “Throughout its history, the club has stood out for its strong work with the youth academy and its ability to compete at a high level within Spanish semi-professional football, establishing itself as a leader in developing young players.” Messi’s move into ownership follows his growing involvement in youth development projects. This places him among a rising number of footballers investing in clubs.

India names coaches for Esports Nations Cup 2026, begins selection

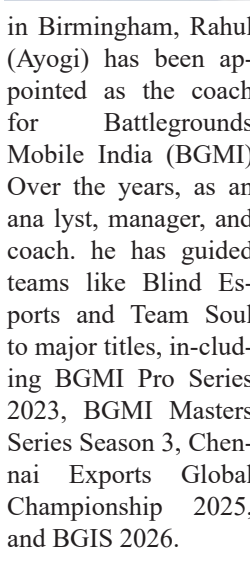
India, on Wednesday (April 22 2026), became one of the 12 countries selected by FIFA for the FIFA Women's Development Programme (Commercial Strategy 2026). The other countries include Germany, the Netherlands, Sweden, Scotland, Canada, Mexico, Finland, Ghana, Jordan, Lithuania, and Paraguay. India's inclusion in the programme was confirmed by FIFA after an initial application by AIFF, which was followed by a detailed presentation of the



Secretary General M. Satyanarayan said, “I think this is the perfect time for us to grow the commercial aspect of women’s football in India as a whole. The qualification of three of our women’s teams (senior, U20, and U17) for the AFC Asian Cups in their respective age categories shows our potential, and the AS- MITA U13 Women’s Football League has helped us create the base at the youth level. “Now that the clubs will receive this kind of capacity building on developing commercial strategies, secur-

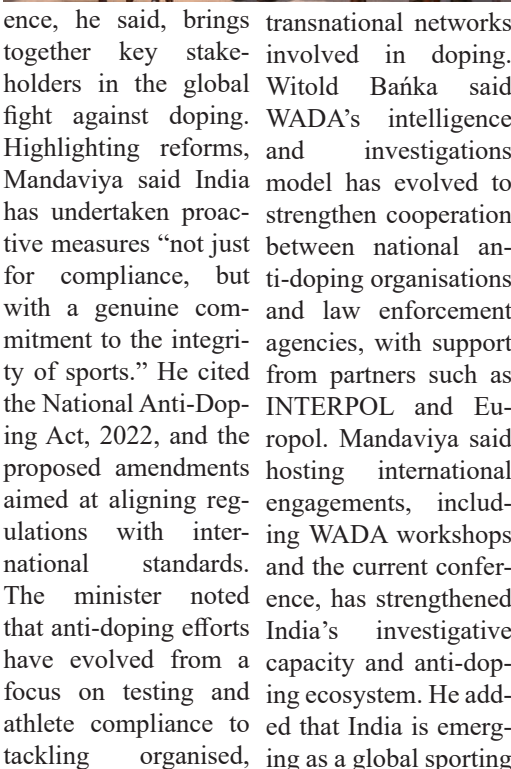
ing sponsorships, engaging fans, and much more, the whole ecosystem will benefit," he said. "I think the initiative by FIFA is excellent, and we are glad to have been selected for it. We hope that the clubs and stakeholders in women's football will benefit from this, especially with IWL clubs coming under club licensing requirements very soon, as set by the AFC." FIFA has supported the Indian football ecosystem for years, with the then FIFA President Sepp Blatter even calling it a "sleeping giant".

India's coaching line-up for the inaugural edition of the Esports Nations Cup 2026 (ENC) has been confirmed, marking the official start of player selection for the country's campaign at the global nation-based esports competition set to debut in Riyadh from November 2-29, 2026. This comes as the Esports Foundation (EF) confirmed the appointment of over 700 Game Coaches representing the NTPs from more than 100 nations and territories, under-



R Vaishali Wins FIDE Women's Candidates, To Face Ju Wenjun For World Championship Title

Union Minister for Youth Affairs and Sports Mansukh Mandaviya on Thursday (April 16 2026) said the government is working to introduce criminal provisions against individuals involved in administering or trafficking prohibited substances. Speaking at the opening of the final conference of the World Anti-Doping Agency's Global Anti-Doping Intelligence and Investigations Network (GAIIN), Mandaviya emphasised India's commitment to fair play and international collaboration in the fight against doping. He underlined the need for global cooperation, stating that such a network can significantly enhance intelligence-sharing and investigative capabilities. The confer-



power. He also highlighted initiatives such as the Khelo India and the Fit India Movement, noting their role in promoting sports and fitness across the country. Emphasising ethics, the minister said “athlete values must remain at the core of sporting excellence,” adding that awareness and education are key to preventing both intentional and inadvertent doping violations. He said the National Anti-Doping Agency follows a multi-layered strategy to raise awareness through workshops, seminars, and digital campaigns, including specialised modules for athletes with disabilities. Anant Kumar, Director General of NADA India, said testing has expanded alongside a shift towards risk-based and intelligence-driven approaches.

India's R Vaishali on Wednesday (April 15, 2026) won the FIDE Women's Candidates Tournament 2026, earning the chance to compete for the World Championship against Ju Wenjun later this year. The 24-year-old secured her victory in dramatic style, finishing with 8.5/14 after defeating Kateryna Lagno in the final round with the white pieces. She played calmly and effectively, finishing half a point ahead of the field. This victory marked an incredible turnaround, as she had started the tournament as one of the lowest-rated players. Vaishali's journey mirrored D Gukesh's fairytale run in 2024, when he also overcame the odds to win the Candidates. After finishing joint second in 2024 with 7.5 points, Vaishali

improved by one point this time to claim the top prize. In her decisive game, Vaishali maintained her composure throughout. Her opening strategy worked flawlessly, giving her an early advantage that she methodically converted into a win. With a pawn advantage, she handled the middlegame with great accuracy and executed several crucial moves around the second time control. Each move required careful precision to preserve her lead, and any mistake could have allowed her opponent to catch up. However, Vaishali stayed focused and finished the game nearly flawlessly. Although her win was critical, she also needed favourable results elsewhere to secure overall victory. Fellow Indian player Divya Deshmukh played a key role by drawing

